3.1 Tensions with Mexico

When you heat water in a teakettle, pressure builds until the water reaches the boiling point. In the 1840s, tensions between the United States and Mexico reached their boiling point: war.

MAIN IDEA The annexation of Texas upset the balance of slave and free states and led to the Mexican-American War.

POLK'S MISSION

James K. Polk was a firm believer in the concept of manifest destiny. When he became president in 1844, he focused on territorial expansion, including the annexation of Texas and the acquisition of California and Oregon. Southerners favored Polk because of his plans to annex Texas. Since slavery had long been practiced there, Texas would join the Union as a slave state. This infuriated northerners because it meant that slave states would outnumber free states. The threat of an unequal number of slave and free states had already reared its head in 1820, with Missouri's request to become a state. The political firestorm that ensued led to a solution in the Missouri Compromise. That solution proved to be temporary, as Congress voted to annex Texas as a new slave state in 1845.



AMERICAN PLACES

Big Bend National Park, Texas

Big Bend National Park is a protected area of canyons and waterfalls at the southernmost bend of the Rio Grande. The river forms the border between Mexico and the United States for about 1,000 miles. At the beginning of the Mexican-American War in 1846, the border, and therefore access to this important river, was disputed.

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CROSSING THE NUECES RIVER

Relations between the United States and Mexico had been tense since the creation of the Republic of Texas. Mexican president Antonio López de Santa Anna had signed the Treaties of Velasco, giving Texas its independence, but the Mexican government never formally acknowledged the treaties as legal. Santa Anna had signed the treaties while he was a prisoner of the Texan Army, they argued, and therefore Texas was still a part of Mexico. Given this history, it's not surprising that Texas's annexation further worsened relations between the United States and Mexico.

At the time, Texas extended only as far south as the Nueces River. President Polk insisted that Texas's southern border should be the Rio Grande, much farther south than the Nueces. In July 1845, Polk sent American troops, led by General **Zachary Taylor**, to secure the area between the Rio Grande and the Nueces River. Polk also sent John Slidell, a **diplomat**, or person sent to represent a country, to Mexico City with an offer. Texas would extend to the Rio Grande, and the United States would buy California for $25 million. The Mexican government refused to negotiate.

Hearing about the snub, Polk told Taylor to advance on the Rio Grande. A skirmish between American and Mexican troops near the river gave Polk the excuse he needed to call for war. In an address to Congress, he declared that Mexico "has invaded our territory and shed American blood upon American soil." Even the Whigs, who had wanted to avoid conflict with Mexico, gave in. The **Mexican-American War** started on May 13, 1846.

Although Congress voted overwhelmingly in favor of the war, many Americans opposed Polk's tactics. Notable New Englanders, including John Quincy Adams and James Russell Lowell, claimed the war was a scheme to expand slavery. Henry David Thoreau even landed in jail when he refused to pay taxes to support the war. Abraham Lincoln, then a young congressman from Illinois, agreed with the New Englanders. He demanded an answer from Polk about "the particular spot of soil on which the blood of our citizens was so shed." Despite the protests, the United States remained at war with Mexico for more than a year.



Dallas Historical Society
Dallas, Texas

Zachary Taylor is memorialized as the king of diamonds on this 19th-century playing card. He is wearing a bicorn hat and elaborate epaulettes, or shoulder ornaments—both of which were typical of American and European military officers beginning in the 1790s.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What did President Polk want from Mexico, and how did the president of Mexico respond?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What were the causes of the Mexican-American War?
3. **EVALUATE** How did President Polk use emotion to persuade Congress to vote for war with Mexico?

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